

Implied Texture

Suggesting complexity with minimal marks

Implied texture means letting the viewer's brain fill in detail you haven't explicitly drawn. Mastery of implied texture is what distinguishes economical, powerful drawings from overworked, detail-obsessed ones.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Principle of Suggestion

You don't need to draw every hair on a head — draw enough to establish the pattern, rhythm, and direction, then stop. The brain completes the rest. This is economy of means: maximum impression with minimum marks.

Edge Quality as Texture

The quality of an edge implies texture without drawing the texture itself. A rough, broken edge implies rough surface. A smooth, continuous edge implies smooth surface. Varying edge quality throughout a drawing creates rich texture differentiation with very few marks.

Selective Detail

Place your most detailed, explicit texture work at the focal point. Move away from the focal point toward simplification and suggestion. This gradient from explicit to implied guides the eye and creates depth.

Knowing When to Stop

The hardest skill in drawing is knowing when to stop. Over-rendering kills implied texture — it becomes explicit texture, and then it becomes noise. Stop before you think you're done; look at it fresh in an hour.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a head of hair with only 20 total strokes. Imply the rest.
 2. Draw a furry animal with no more than 50 marks. Use edge quality to imply texture.
 3. Copy a master sketch — count how few marks the master uses to imply texture.
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FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Economy of Marks

<https://youtu.be/OcJPNMFFKHs>

■ Ctrl+Paint – Implied Detail